

ASHOK RAO/DIVYA BHASKAR



UP IN ARMS: A group of tribals armed with bows and arrows, pickaxes and other weapons at the village of Atarsumba

forestland, he has demanded an inquiry by the National Human Rights Commission. "I am for the protection of tribals' rights through constitutional means. I have nothing to do with BAMCEF," he clarifies.

Says Mahendrasin Parmar, divisional forest officer, Sabarkantha, "The fact that the tribals, under the influence of BAMCEF, took possession of forestland that they had never cultivated, proves they don't really want to protect their rights through constitutional ways. BAMCEF's activities have all the trappings of a semi-Naxalite movement." Further proof of local Congress leaders backing the organisation for their own political reasons came when Kotwal attended BAMCEF meetings—pictures of him sharing the dais with BAMCEF leaders were published in newspapers. Ramesh Desai, assistant conservator of forests, came face to face with the violent nature of BAMCEF when he went to negotiate with the tribals, only to find that they were armed. Says Desai, "As soon as we approached them, they started raising war cries in their language to the beat of drums. Flaunting their bows and arrows, they warned us that any attempt to forcibly evict them would lead to bloodshed."

Warnings also materialised on buildings in the Polo area, threatening

Mayur Mistry, an environmental activist and management expert, with death if he didn't leave the area. Mistry had been co-opted by the Forest Department to create employment opportunities for tribals by training them to become tourist guides. Soon after, he left the forest for the safety of Ahmedabad, his hometown. Experts say BAMCEF's strategy—of identifying an area and then targeting people in important positions who are seen as impediments to the spread of its ideology—is not unlike that of ultra outfits. Says Anil Johri, conservator of forests, who is in charge of the Polo jungles, "The BAMCEF movement is like the Naxalite movement in its initial stages."

Though the Government has deployed additional reserve police force in the area to maintain peace, the greatest challenge for the police now is to trace 'outside' links. Villagers say some local BAMCEF activists had gone to Bihar two months ago and then to Dungarpur in Rajasthan to attend crucial meetings.

When INDIA TODAY tried to establish

contact with BAMCEF, none of its activists could be traced in the area and villagers said they had all gone underground following strong police action. Amraji Dabhi, an activist from Abhapur village who was arrested by the police and later released on bail, denied any links with the outfit, though several officials of the Forest Department vouch for the fact that he is a BAMCEF activist. The chief of the Gujarat unit of BAMCEF, Govind Parmar, vehemently denies that it is an ultra organisation, saying that it "works for the uplift of backward classes through peaceful and constitutional means and its work is mainly amongst Government employees". He passes the blame on to Madhusudan, saying, "It was because of his provocative speeches that the Adivasis indulged in violence. Just because some BAMCEF activists were present to hear his speeches doesn't mean that they were involved." S.S. Dhammy, general secretary of the national BAMCEF body, is even more defensive: "We don't indulge in violence. I am not even aware of this Polo violence."

For all the fear it has instilled in the locals, BAMCEF still remains a fairly small unit in Polo. Its membership in the area reportedly ranges between 2,000 and 4,000

BAMCEF's strategy of targeting those who are seen as impediments to its ideology is not unlike that of ultra outfits.

and doesn't extend beyond 10 villages. Says Kanubhai Ninama, a member of the Abhapur village eco-development committee set up by the state Government to protect biodiversity in the area and train tribals for employment, "The support base of BAMCEF is still very small. A majority of villagers are angry with it after

the activists chopped off so many trees." Clearly, the raw material needed for an ultra movement is in short supply in the forests of Sabarkantha. But after tasting defeat thrice in a row, it will suit Chief Minister Narendra Modi's political and ideological rivals to whip up the forestland issue in a bid to put his Government on the mat. ■